RAJASTHAN/ RAJE-PILOT

SEASON OF ROADSHOWS

By Rohit Parihar



ANI

SAY IT WITH ROSES Vasundhara Raje during her visit to Bikaner



ROUSING RECEPTION Crowds mill around Sachin Pilot in Kota

Vasundhara Raje may not be the most popular leader with the BJP high command but there's no denying her place among the people in Rajasthan. The former chief minister was in Bikaner district in the northwest of the state on October 9-10 on a pilgrimage-cum-personal visit and was attracting crowds in the thousands even as the local BJP apparatus—including local MP and Union minister Arjun Singh Meghwal—stayed away. Meanwhile, two heavyweight opponents were trying to challenge her in her den, Jhalawar and Baran, in southeast Rajasthan, in her absence. Raje represents Jhalrapatan in Jhalawar in the assembly and her son Dushyant is the Jhalawar-Baran MP.

On October 10, state BJP chief Satish Poonia, who is eyeing a second term, did a roadshow in Baran while Congress leader and former deputy CM Sachin Pilot, who is looking to dislodge CM Ashok Gehlot, was part of a rally from Kota to Jhalawar where he presided over a function of the Akhil Bharatiya Yadav Mahasabha (Yuva). Poonia was allegedly a facilitator for Pilot and his MLAs when the latter had attempted his shortlived revolt in July 2020. The two may be holding a grudge as Raje had allegedly refused to back the move to topple Gehlot (which, it seems, ended her war with the latter).

The Kota division, which includes Jhalawar, Baran, Bundi and Kota districts, has immense political significance. BJP president J.P. Nadda will soon hold a booth-level meeting of party workers of the Kota division and local leaders have perked up in a bid to impress him. Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla represents Kota-Bundi and is among the few leaders seen as a possible successor to Raje. The lady herself seemed unperturbed by the flurry of activity, for the very next day (October 11) she was out on an aerial survey of the region and talking to farmers to assess the damage from the heavy, unseasonal rainfall.

The events of the two days have set in motion power struggles in both the BJP and Congress. In the coming weeks, the cracks could well begin to get visible. Pilot's show saw little participation of leaders from the Gehlot camp, including Shanti Dhariwal, the powerful minister from Kota at whose residence many MLAs had gathered to scuttle the high command's move to replace Gehlot at the Congress legislature party (CLP) meet on September 25. Pilot still got a warm welcome at Kota railway station from where he